Lycoris

Click me：https://youtu.be/kVGB4noxZYs

Playable version： https://kyukao.itch.io/lycoris

Team Pojrect. A team of 7 members.

Engine: Unity URP Pipeline

Responsibilities: Technical Artist / Project Management

A narrative-driven platformer puzzle game set in the Chinese underworld. Players take on the role of a mortal who made a pact with a demon—venturing into the underworld to rescue their deceased loved one, while mastering soul-body shifting.

Centered on "Chinese underworld" aesthetics, the game features a dark crimson netherworld with Buddhist/Taoist symbols, using Red Spider Lily (Lycoris radiata) and the Bridge of Helplessness as core narrative motifs. Navigate perilous environments via key mechanics: astral projection, ghost flame manipulation, and Yin-Yang formation puzzles—all against striking light-shadow contrast

One special point is that we learned to make a trailer for this special game, during which we mastered the use of Timeline and Cinematic Events to handle camera events skillfully—and the whole process and the final effect were truly amazing!

Trailer：https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Gen78RAZ3zE

Inspiration

WHY ?

We agreed to develop a game rooted in Chinese stories. Our lead designer Tristan favors "other shore" and "underworld" themes—thus, we'll create a game with distinct "Chinese underworld style."

- *Ancient Chinese architecture*
- *Buddhist/Taoist symbols (integrated into puzzles/decorations)*

Among these, the Lycoris and the Bridge of Inevitability serve as core elements. Lycoris, which blooms when leaves are absent and bears leaves when flowers are gone, symbolizes lovers separated by life and death, forever unable to me

The Bridge of Inevitability stands as the sole path linking "this shore" to the "other shore." In the game, the hero strides resolutely toward this bridge, detaching from his physical shell to traverse to the "other shore" in his unwavering quest for his beloved.

We've decided to craft a story that feels somewhat like a ***Chinese adaptation of the myth of Orpheus and Eurydice****.*

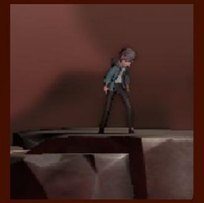
Concept

Experience and Gameplay

The player takes on the role of someone who made a deal with a demon and gained the ability to shift between soul and body. He then ventures into the underworld to rescue his deceased wife. The deeper he goes, the more he realizes he is gradually turning into a soul—and that abandoning his physical form is the only way to stay with her. The character can astrally project his soul, inheriting the body's momentum while becoming lighter and gaining the ability to interact with supernatural beings. Players use this ability to solve puzzles.

Game pillar

Body carrying a soul:
Heavy + Basic movement + Can be regenerated by the soul.



Soul:
Lightweight + Incorporea + Capable of interacting with ghostly flames.

Body without a soul:
Heavy + Immobile + Auto destroyed when Regenerated

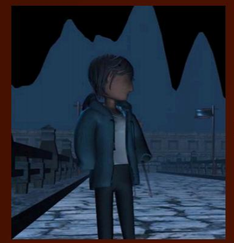
Story background

01

A man awakens in the underworld to find he possesses a new ability: his soul can leave his body. By repeatedly projecting his soul and leaping from his physical form, he traverses the treacherous terrain of hell. This power offers him a chance to bring his wife back from the depths of the underworld.

02

He arrives at a field brimming with Lycoris , which stir memories of the joyful times he shared with his wife. Suddenly, the flowers transform into ghostly flames, searing his hands. Though he loses his physical hands, his soul grows significantly stronger.



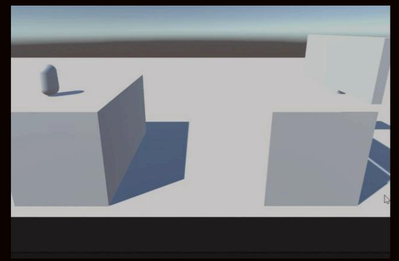
03

He presses on with his adventure, harnessing the power that resonates with the ghostly flames to unlock mechanisms. As a soul, he grows increasingly powerful. Finally, he finds his wife —but only a soul may pass forward, meaning he must abandon his physical form to be with her. So he resolutely casts his body aside and continues walking toward her.

Producing Process

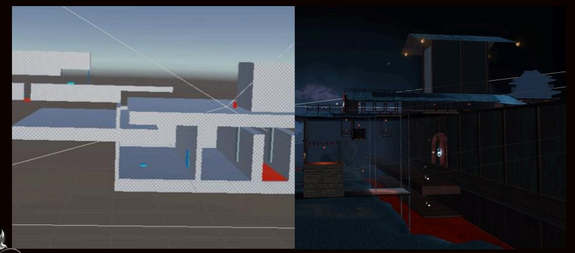
Prototype ––> Muture Levels

*The overall gameplay perspective, lighting, and rendering style of the game are inspired by **Inside.***



We adopt a branch-based approach for production. The Gameplay programmers and the lead planner independently verify the 3C and develop the game prototype in the Design branch.

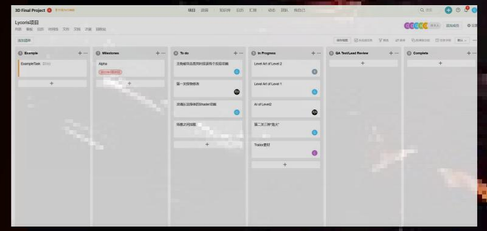
The designer created the basic layout of the level using whiteboxes to represent collision areas.



I independently utilized assets to construct an art scene complete with lighting effects. Once he finalized the level modifications, I merged the art assets with the whiteboxes in accordance with scene art standards.

Project Management

I also served as the project manager for this project, utilizing Tower for team management.

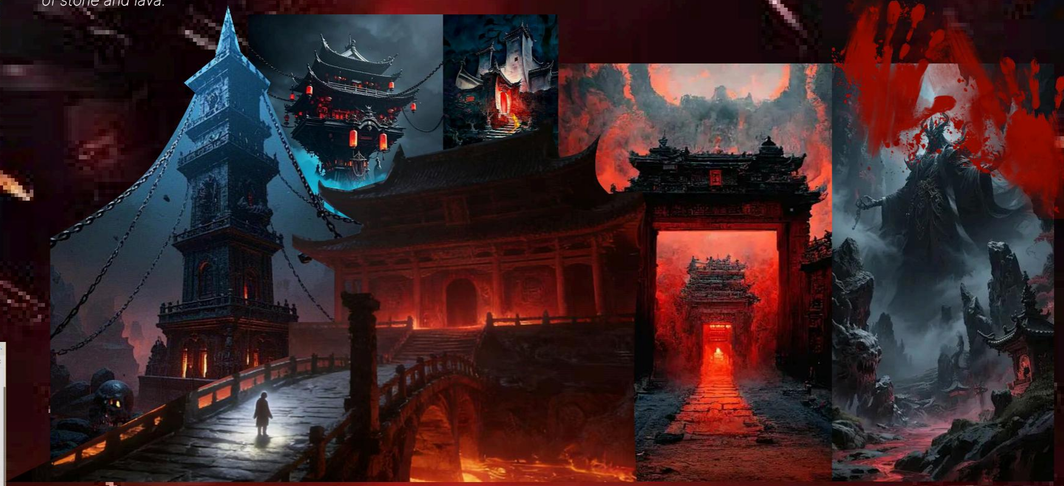


My responsibilities included conducting weekly team meetings to track progress, reporting updates to the instructor, documenting meeting notes to gather feedback, facilitating follow-up discussions to explore improvement strategies, and continuously adjusting plans based on the team members' productivity.

Scene Art

Visual reference

For the visual aspects, we drew inspiration from the Chinese conceptualization of the underworld. The game begins at the edge of hell and progresses all the way to the Gate of the Underworld. My environmental art work focused on the first part, where I created a world composed of stone and lava.



Art Style Direction: A hellscape dominated by dark red tones, with the blue protagonist standing out against the crimson backdrop of the underworld.

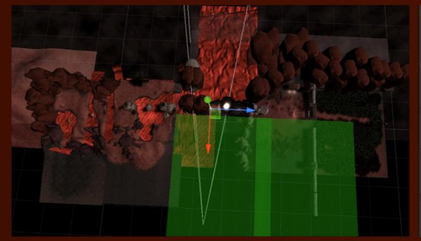
Scene Art

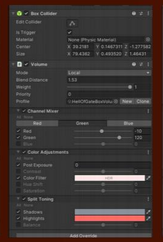
Level Art

Game starts — Cave — Ruin — Gate of Hell

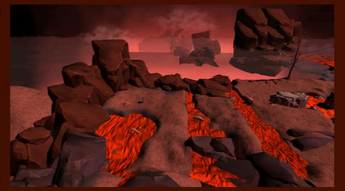
Scenario Setting

*To achieve a 2D side-scrolling effect, we set **FOV 10**. We placed objects far apart, arranged art assets in layers separated by volumetric fog, used **different directional lights for each scene section**, and applied Depth of Field and Box post-processing to adjust colors and mood. Thus we could create varied atmospheres in one scene*





I used different directional lights for each section of the scene—key light, fill light, and platform accent light—to visually separate them.



Project iteration started from 2026

After interning as a TA, when I looked back at this project, I found there were many areas that could be iterated on.
I believe the environment should feel more abstract rather than literal; instead of balanced lighting, we should emphasize stronger light and shadow contrasts.

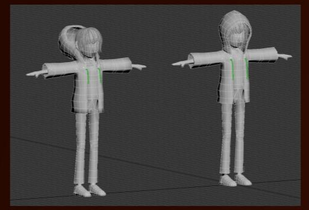
New Rules I set:

1. *All shaders must avoid realistic textures, using more stylized patterns.*
2. *A HeroLight is used to setup the player character;*
3. *Corresponding lights should be added at all self-illuminating scene areas, in order to highlight characters and enhance danger.*

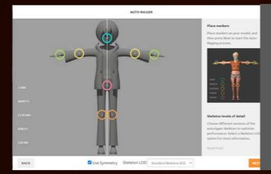
Character

Character Design

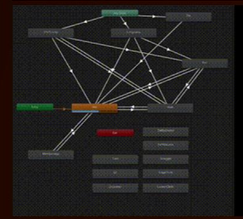
Our art direction envisions the protagonist as a slender, introverted young man, whose identity is defined by his daily habit of wearing a hoodie. His modern attire creates a striking contrast when he enters the discordant realm of hell. Nevertheless, his animations will emphasize his unwavering determination to save his wife.



Character Art & Animation



I used Mixamo for character rigging, adjusted the animations, and wrote code to integrate them with the character mechanics programmed by the lead developer.

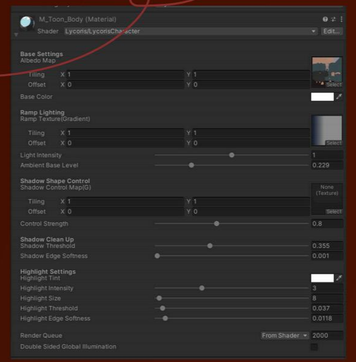


Between the first and second levels, the character's hands are burned by the Red Spider Lilies. Consequently, two models and four animation controllers are required. I also utilized a dissolve shader to express the transition between the body and the soul.

Iterative Rendering

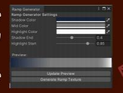
After studying shader techniques and revisiting the rendering approach of Inside, I realized that the previous character design required a major overhaul.

Blinn-Phong base + Threshold/Softness, clipped with SmoothStep.Highlights only on key objects: sharp, high-contrast, distinct shape.



Black/white mask to offset/push/pull shadow edges via displacement.Enforce clean, stylized shadows even with imperfect topology.

C# Ramp generator for real-time gradient tweaking & preview on character.Light gray → deep blue ramp for customizable light/shadow transition.

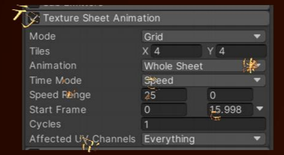


Gameplay VFX

Yin Yang Plate

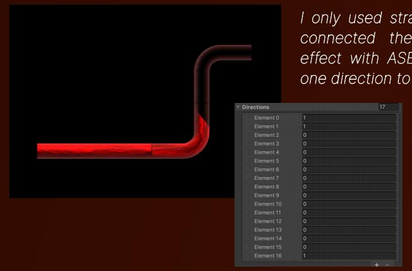
Each formation requires the absorption of both life and death energy. The character must keep his body on the Yang platform while guiding his soul to the Yin platform to activate this mechanism.

Floating Text :



Blood Pipeline

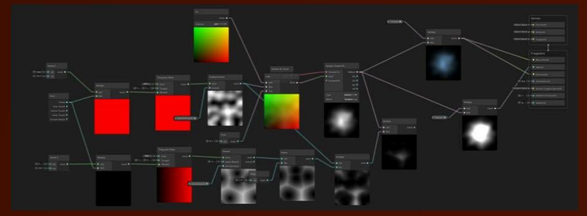
This is a sacrificial platter. When the player steps on the flesh, blood is squeezed out and flows through the pipes. Only when the blood travels through all the pipes to the gate can it channel the power to open it.
Sometimes the pipes are blocked by talisman papers, and the player must first use their soul to absorb the power of ghost fire to break the seal.



I only used straight pipes and elbows, and connected them together. I created an effect with ASE to make the flow go from one direction to another. The flow direction is exposed as a parameter named 'Direction', which can be controlled in the script of this pipe group.

Interactable Ghost Fire

In Level 2, the character's soul can ***resonate with ghost fire*** *to overcome numerous obstacles.*



I created the basic flame using the Particle System and Shader Graph.
Subsequently, I utilized the Trail module and the Force Over Lifetime parameter of the Particle System to control the direction of the flame's tail, giving it a pulled and stretched visual effect.

After extensive testing, I opted to use trigonometric functions to calculate the flame's end variations. The game features three distinct ghost flame mechanics.

Ghost Fire on Spell

resonate with the fire
to burn talisman

Ghost Fire on Box

resonate with the fire
to pull the cage

Individual Ghost Fire

resonate with the fire
to pull oneself

Talisman

Talisman Die Out ⟶ Dissolve Shader with Burn Ramp